

How to Write an Effective Claim (with Examples)

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Formulating a claim for your essay can be difficult even if you are already a masterful debater — especially if you are not quite sure what a claim is, and how it may differ from a counterclaim or thesis statement. This guide will make it easy to decide on your claim!

Essay Claim Basics

In essay writing, a claim can most **succinctly** be defined as "a debatable statement" — which the writer then **defends** with supporting evidence and **rhetoric**. It is easy to confuse a claim and a thesis statement, because the thesis is indeed a type of claim as well. Essays can contain further claims that **orbit** the topic of the thesis statement, however.

Claims **straddle** the line between opinion and fact. If you're hoping to make a strong claim that **seamlessly** fits into a powerful essay, you will need to make sure that your claim ticks the right boxes:

Your claim can be debated — solid arguments can be made both in favor and against. Therefore, statements such as "I live in Queens" or "Joe Biden is the President" are not claims. In an argumentative essay, "the death penalty should be abolished" is an example of a claim. Even scientific papers make claims, such as "Keyboards contain more germs than toilet seats", which can be tested. These are called hypotheses.

You will state your claim as a matter of fact. "Many people oppose the death penalty, and with good reason" is not a good claim, but "the death penalty is no longer an appropriate punishment in modern America" can be.

Your claim is **sufficiently** specific to allow you to explore all aspects that you intend to **tackle**. "The Victorian era was Britain's darkest era" gives you more bite than you can comfortably chew. "Fast food should be taxed to reduce obesity rates" is more specific.

Types of Claim (With Examples!)

Claims are debatable statements, but there are numerous different types. If you have specifically been asked to present a claim in an essay, you may be able to choose what kind of claim you would like to work with.

1. Claim of Fact or Definition

In research essays, a claim of fact or definition is one that defines a fact, as you see it, and proceeds to **lay out** the evidence in favor of the claim. Here are some examples to show you how it works:

Amazon's Alexa has revolutionized many people's daily lives — but this appliance also makes us vulnerable to new forms of hacking.

Commercial air travel transformed the way in which we do business.

2. Claim of Value

Claims of value are more heavily opinion-based than other types of claims. If you are making a claim of value, you will usually want to compare two things. For example:

Emotional health is just as important as physical health.

Stephen King is the best horror writer of all time.

3. Claim of Solution or Policy

Claims of solution or policy state a position on a proposed course of action. In high school and college essays, they typically focus on something that should be done, or something that should no longer be done. Examples might include:

Depressed patients should always be offered talk therapy before they receive a prescription for **antidepressants**.

First-time offenders should be given lighter sentences.

Claim vs. Counterclaim vs. Thesis Statement

If you've been told to make an essay claim, you may be confused about the differences between a claim, counterclaim, and thesis statement. That's understandable, because some people believe that there's no difference between a claim and a thesis statement.

There are important distinctions between these three concepts, however, and if you want to write a killer essay, it's important to be aware of them:

A **thesis statement** is the very foundation of your essay — everything else rests on it. The thesis statement should contain no more than one or two sentences, and summarize the heart of your argument. "Regular exercise has consistently been shown to increase productivity in the workplace. Therefore, employers should offer office workers, who would otherwise be largely **sedentary**, opportunities to work out."

A **claim** is a statement you can defend with arguments and evidence. A thesis statement is a type of claim, but you'll want to include other claims that fit neatly into the subject matter as well. For instance, "Employers should establish gyms for employees."

A **counterclaim** is a statement that contradicts, refutes, or opposes a claim. Why would you want to argue against yourself? You can do so to show that arguments that oppose the claim are weak. For instance, "Many employers would **balk** at the idea of facilitating costly exercise classes or providing a gym space — employees can work out in their own time, after all. Why should the boss pay for workers to engage in recreational activities at work? Recent studies have shown, however, that workplaces that have incorporated aerobics classes enjoy 120% increase in productivity, showing that this step serves **the bottom line**."

Together, a thesis statement, claims, and some well-placed counterclaims make up the **threads** of your story, leading to a coherent essay that is interesting to read.

How to Write an Effective Claim

Now that you've seen some examples, you are well on your way to writing an effective claim for your essay. Need some extra tips? We've got you covered.

First things first — how do you start a claim in an essay? Your claim sentence or sentences should be written in the active voice, starting with the subject, so that your readers can immediately understand what you are talking about.

They'll be formulated as an "[Subject] should be [proposed action], because [argument]. You can stay with this general structure while making different word choices, however, such as:

Must

It is about time that

We have an obligation to

Is the only logical choice

It is imperative that

Once you have **formulated** a claim, you will want to see if you can **hook** your readers with an interesting or **provocative** statement that can really get them thinking. You will want to break your argument down into sections. This will lead you to sub-claims. If your claim is your main argument, your sub-claims are smaller arguments that work to support it. They will typically appear naturally once you **contemplate** the subject deeply — just brainstorm, and as you research, keep considering why your claim is true. The reasons you come up with will **sprout** sub-claims.

Additional Tips in Writing a Claim the Right Way

You now know what you need to include in a claim paragraph to leave a strong impression. Understanding what not to do is equally important, however.

Do:

Take a stand — if you're writing an argumentative essay, it is perfectly OK to take a controversial opinion, and no matter what you write, it is bound to have the potential to offend someone. Don't sit on the fence. Even when you're defending a position you disagree with, embrace it **wholeheartedly**.

Narrow your claim down. The more specific you can get, the more **compelling** your argument can be, and the more depth you can add to each aspect of your argument.

Have fun! You want your essay to be interesting to read, and any genuine passion you have will be apparent.

Choose the right subject — one about which you can find a lot of data and facts.

What should you avoid in writing a claim, you wonder? Don't:

Use any first-person statements. The claim is about your ideas, not about you.

Base your claim on emotional appeal. You can work some pathos in, but don't make feelings

your center.

Clutter your claim with too many separate ideas, which will make the rest of your essay harder to read, less powerful, and unwieldy for you to develop.

单词、音标及词性	词义	例句
formulate /'fɔ:rmjʊleɪt/ v.	阐述；规划	She will formulate a new strategy for the project.
succinctly /sək'sɪŋktli/ adv.	简洁地	He explained the complex theory succinctly in one paragraph.
defend /dɪ'fend/ v.	辩护；保卫	The lawyer will defend the client with strong evidence.
rhetoric /'rɛtərɪk/ n.	修辞；花言巧语	Her speech was full of persuasive rhetoric .
orbit /'ɔ:rbɪt/ v.	绕轨道运行；围绕	The satellite will orbit the Earth.
straddle /'strædl/ v.	跨坐；跨越	The new policy attempts to straddle both economic and social issues.
seamlessly /'si:mləsli/ adv.	无缝地；流畅地	The new software integrates seamlessly with existing systems.
sufficiently /sə'fɪʃəntli/ adv.	足够地	The data is sufficiently reliable to support the claim.
tackle /'tækl/ v.	处理；解决	The team must tackle the problem before the deadline.
lay out phr.v.	布置；阐述	The report will lay out the details of the proposal.
antidepressant /ˌæntɪdɪ'presənt/ n.	抗抑郁药	Doctors sometimes prescribe an antidepressant for severe depression.
sedentary /'sedəntəri/ adj.	久坐的	A sedentary lifestyle can lead to health problems.
balk /bɔ:k/ v.	犹豫；拒绝	Many companies balk at the high cost of implementation.
the bottom line n.	底线；关键点	The bottom line is that we need to increase profits.
thread /θred/ n.	线；线索	The story has many threads that connect at the end.
hook /hʊk/ v.	钩住；吸引	The advertisement aims to hook customers with a catchy slogan.
provocative /prə'vɔ:kətɪv/ adj.	挑衅的；煽动的	His provocative comments sparked a heated debate.

单词、音标及词性	词义	例句
contemplate /'kɑːntəmpleɪt/ v.	沉思；考虑	She stopped to contemplate her next move.
sprout /spraʊt/ v.	发芽；产生	New ideas often sprout during brainstorming sessions.
wholeheartedly /ˌhoʊl'haːrtɪdli/ adv.	全心全意地	He supports the new policy wholeheartedly .
compelling /kəm'pelɪŋ/ adj.	引人入胜的；有说服力的	The evidence presented was compelling and convincing.
clutter /'klʌt.ə(r)/ v.	使杂乱，乱堆放	Don't clutter the hallway with your shoes and bags.

Exercises:

I. 选词填空

Instructions: Complete the following sentences using the words provided in the box. Use each word only once.

lay out/defend/contemplate/tackle/hook/clutter/balk/formulate

- Before we begin the project, we need to _____ a clear plan of action to guide our team.
- The senator prepared to _____ her controversial policy proposal against fierce criticism from the opposition.
- The article is poorly written because it's _____ with unnecessary jargon.
- The complexity of the philosophical question made him pause and _____ its deeper meaning for a long time.
- The first sentence of your essay needs to _____ the reader's attention immediately.
- Many homeowners _____ at the high cost of renovating their old properties.
- The manager called a meeting to _____ the specific steps required to complete the project on time.
- To _____ this difficult problem effectively, we must first understand its root cause.

II. 词汇替换

Instructions: Choose the most appropriate word or phrase from the options (A, B, C, D) to replace the underlined part in each sentence without changing its original meaning.

- The CEO explained the new company strategy clearly and concisely in a five-minute video.
 - thoroughly
 - efficiently
 - succinctly
 - in detail
- The data was not adequately robust to support such a strong conclusion.
 - completely
 - sufficiently

- C. entirely
- D. essentially

3. Her new job responsibilities bridge the gap between the marketing and design teams.

- A. straddle
- B. connect
- C. unite
- D. integrate

4. The updated software integrated smoothly and without any issues into our existing workflow.

- A. without a hitch
- B. effectively
- C. adequately
- D. seamlessly

5. We can discuss the details later, but the most important thing is that we need to increase sales this quarter.

- A. the key issue
- B. the bottom line
- C. the primary goal
- D. in short

III. 翻译 Translate the following sentences from Chinese to English.

1. 在议论文写作中，主张最简洁的定义是“一个可被辩论的陈述”。
2. 中心论点是整篇文章的基石，它应该概括你论证的核心。
3. 主张（claim）和论点（argument）不同；主张是你所声明的观点，而论点是你用来支持该观点的理由。
4. 提出一个反主张（counterclaim）来反驳自己，是为了展示相反的论点是薄弱的。
5. 一个有效的主张必须足够具体，并且能够通过证据和逻辑来捍卫。